The Failure Story

The cancelled society event. Why it is a good choice, why "we didn't sell enough tickets" is not yet a failure, and how to find the one that is actually yours.

Doc 39 · "Tell me about a time you failed" · Asset Management, Client Solutions Group · Prepared 4 November 2026

1 What this question is actually testing

Three things, and almost everybody misses the third.

Test	What they are looking for
1. Honesty	Did you pick a real failure, or a success wearing a costume? Reviewers have heard "I worked too hard on a project" hundreds of times and it reads as evasion.
2. Diagnosis	Do you know *why* it happened, precisely? Anybody can describe a bad outcome. Being able to name the decision that caused it is the actual signal.
3. Evidence you changed	**The one nearly everyone misses.** A lesson with no subsequent behaviour attached is just a nice sentence. The strongest failure answers end with *"and here is what I did differently next time."*

> Scale does not matter. A cancelled society social is a perfectly good failure. **What matters is the quality of the diagnosis, not the size of the disaster.**

So do not worry that this feels small. In fact small is safer — you do not want to confess to something that makes you look negligent with money or with people. But there is a floor, and it is this: **you must be able to point to a decision you made that contributed.** If the honest truth is "nobody came because it clashed with something we could not have known about," that is bad luck, not failure, and the answer will not work.

2 The five ways people ruin this answer

Failure mode	What it sounds like, and why it fails
The fake failure	"I took on too much because I'm so committed." A humble-brag. Reads as unwilling to answer the question.
The deflection	"The team didn't pull their weight." "We were under pressure from the organisers." **This is your biggest risk** — see section 6.
The symptom, not the cause	"We didn't sell enough tickets." That is what *happened*, not what you got *wrong*. This is where you are right now.
The grovel	Excessive apology and self-criticism. It does not read as humility, it reads as poor judgement about proportion.
The empty lesson	"I learned the importance of planning ahead." Says nothing, could be attached to any story, and proves nothing changed.

3 Honest assessment of your story

WHAT'S GOOD ABOUT IT

It is a genuine failure. The event was cancelled. That is binary, visible and undeniable. Many candidates pick something that did not really fail.

There were stakeholders and consequences. Other people were relying on it.

It is the right size. Real enough to be credible, not so serious that it makes you look reckless.

WHAT'S MISSING

No diagnosis. "We didn't sell enough tickets" is the outcome. What caused it?

No ownership. Everything is "we". The question asks about *your* failure.

No number. How many did you sell, against what you needed?

No lesson, and no evidence of change.

You have the event. You do not yet have the failure. **The failure is whatever decision led to there being too few tickets sold — and only you know what it was.**

4 Find your actual failure

Here is a diagnostic menu. Student events fail for a small number of recurring reasons. **Read these and work out honestly which one was yours.** I do not know, and I am not going to guess for you.

Possible cause	What it would have looked like	Strength as an answer
Demand was assumed, not tested	People said they'd come, a poll looked positive, so you committed. Nobody actually bought.	**Strongest.** See section 5.
Fixed costs committed before sales	Venue booked with a minimum spend, so you were chasing a break-even from day one.	**Very strong.** A real sequencing error you can name.
Marketing started too late	Promotion began two weeks out, by which point people had already committed their money and their nights.	Good, if true. Make it specific — how late, and why.
Wrong channel	Posted only where people already following the society would see it, so you reached the converted and nobody else.	Good. Shows you understand reach versus engagement.
Wrong date or price	Clashed with deadlines, fell at the end of term when nobody has money, or priced above what the audience would pay.	Decent. Weaker unless you can say why you chose it.
Nobody owned sales	The committee all assumed somebody else was pushing tickets.	Fine, **but avoid it.** It is the same lesson as your house-hunt story and you should not repeat yourself across answers.

THE QUESTIONS ONLY YOU CAN ANSWER — DO THIS BEFORE ANYTHING ELSE

1. How many tickets did you need, and how many did you sell? Even approximate.

2. What specifically was *your* job on it? Not the committee's — yours.

3. Was there a moment where you could have seen it coming and did not act? That moment is usually the real failure.

4. Who exactly were the "organisers" putting on the pressure — the venue, the SU, the committee? And what were they pressing for?

5 The strongest version, if it is true

If your honest answer to the menu is somewhere near "we thought people wanted it, and they said they did, but not enough of them actually paid" — then you have something genuinely good, and it is your own subject doing the work.

THE ECONOMICS YOU CAN NAME

There is a distinction in economics between **stated preference** — what people say they would do — and **revealed preference** — what their actual choices show.

A student saying "yeah I'll come" in a group chat costs them nothing. It is a stated preference, and it carries almost no information. **Buying a ticket costs them something, which is exactly why it is the only signal that counts.**

So the failure was not that people let you down. It was that **you treated a free signal as if it were a costly one, and built a plan on top of it.**

The one-line version: **a commitment that costs nothing tells you nothing.**

That is a sharp, true, slightly uncomfortable lesson, it is unmistakably an economist's way of putting it, and almost no candidate will say anything like it.

And if it was the fixed-cost sequencing instead

Equally good, different framing: *"We booked the venue before we'd sold anything, which meant we had a break-even to chase rather than a decision to make. If we'd sold first and committed second, the worst case would have been a small event instead of a cancelled one."* That is a sequencing error, you can name it cleanly, and it is a mistake real businesses make constantly.

6 The pressure, and the trap inside it

HANDLE THIS CAREFULLY

You mentioned pressure from the organisers. **That is context. It is not a cause, and if you use it as one, the whole answer collapses into deflection.**

The moment you say "we were under a lot of pressure from the organisers" in a tone that explains the outcome, the reviewer hears: *this person is telling me about a time somebody else failed.*

DEFLECTING

"We were getting a lot of pressure from the organisers, and in the end we just couldn't shift enough tickets, so it had to be cancelled."

Reads as: it was difficult and other people made it worse.

OWNING IT

"There was real pressure from the organisers, and I think that's actually part of why I got it wrong — I was so focused on reassuring them that we'd be fine that I didn't stop and look at what the numbers were actually telling me."

Reads as: someone who can see their own behaviour under stress.

The second version uses the pressure as an explanation of *your* mistake rather than as a substitute for one. That is the move. **Only use it if it is true** — but if you were managing upward and reassuring people rather than looking squarely at the sales numbers, that is a very human and very credible failure, and it is one that genuinely matters in a client-facing job.

7 The part you might get credit for

One nuance worth separating out, because it shows clear thinking.

FAILING AT THE THING AND HANDLING THE FAILURE WELL ARE DIFFERENT

The failure was the demand assumption. The cancellation may have been the correct response to it.

Running a half-empty event at a loss, to avoid the embarrassment of cancelling, would have been worse — that is chasing money you have already spent. Pulling it was the disciplined call.

So you can own the first and defend the second: *"The mistake was earlier than the cancellation. By the time we were deciding whether to pull it, cancelling was clearly the right call — the error was three weeks before that."*

A candidate who can locate *when* the failure actually happened, rather than pointing at the visible bad outcome at the end, is doing something genuinely analytical. Most people point at the cancellation. The cancellation was

the consequence.

8 The bit almost nobody does: evidence you changed

This is the highest-value twenty seconds available to you, and it is sitting right there in your other material.

If your failure was treating free agreement as real commitment, then look at what you did in the house hunt a while later: **you stopped accepting vague agreement and reduced the ask to a yes or no with a date.** That is not a coincidence. That is the same lesson, applied.

WHAT THAT SOUNDS LIKE, IN ONE SENTENCE

"And I did actually use it afterwards — when I was organising a house with five other people the following year, I didn't take 'yeah I'm in' as an answer from anyone. I made everyone give me a yes or no by a date, because I'd learnt that people agreeing to something is not the same as people committing to it."

BUT DO NOT TELL BOTH STORIES IN FULL

If you have already used the house hunt for the teamwork question in the same recording, **reference it in one clause and move on** — do not retell it. And if teamwork has not come up yet, keep this brief so the house story still feels fresh if it does.

9 The full answer

About 105 seconds. Square brackets are yours. Highlighted phrases are doing specific work.

SITUATION — ~18 SECONDS

So this was with the economics society at university. We were putting on a social event, and I was [YOUR SPECIFIC ROLE]. We'd committed to [venue / date / whatever the commitment was], and we needed to sell around [number] tickets to make it work.

WHAT HAPPENED — ~15 SECONDS

We sold [number]. Nowhere near enough. And in the end we had to cancel it, which meant letting down [the organisers / the people who had bought / the committee].

THE DIAGNOSIS — ~30 SECONDS

The thing I'd say now is that the failure happened well before the cancellation. [YOUR REAL CAUSE — e.g.: We'd asked people whether they'd come and the response was really positive, so we went ahead and committed. But nobody had paid anything at that point.] And I think the mistake was that I treated what people said as if it were real demand. Saying yes in a group chat costs you nothing. Buying a ticket costs you something — and that's the only one that actually tells you anything.

[If true: And I think the pressure from the organisers made it worse, because I spent more time reassuring them it'd be fine than I did looking honestly at the sales numbers.]

WHAT I'D DEFEND — ~15 SECONDS

I'd defend the cancellation itself — running it half empty at a loss just to avoid the embarrassment would have been worse. But that was the right call about a situation I'd already got myself into. The error was weeks earlier.

WHAT CHANGED — ~20 SECONDS

What I actually took from it is that a commitment that costs nothing tells you nothing. And I did use it — [BRIEF EXAMPLE, one sentence, e.g.: when I organised a house with five other people the next year, I wouldn't take "yeah I'm in" from anybody, I made everyone give me a yes or no by a date]. Which sounds small, but it's the bit I actually changed.

10 Weak version versus strong version

WHAT MOST PEOPLE WOULD SAY

"I was part of the economics society and we were organising a social event. Unfortunately we didn't manage to sell enough tickets, and there was a lot of pressure from the organisers, so in the end we had to cancel it."

"It was disappointing and I was quite upset about it."

"I learned the importance of marketing and planning ahead, and of starting things earlier."

YOURS, DIAGNOSED

"We needed [X] tickets. We sold [Y]. We cancelled."

"But the failure was weeks before the cancellation. We asked people if they'd come, got a good response, and committed on the back of it — and nobody had paid anything at that point."

"I treated what people said as if it were demand. Saying yes costs nothing. Buying a ticket costs something. Only one of those tells you anything."

"I'd defend pulling it. Running it half empty to save face would have been worse. But that was a good decision about a hole I'd already dug."

"And I did change it — [one-line example]."

What changed	Why it scores
Numbers	"Needed X, sold Y" makes it real in four seconds.
The failure is located in time	"Weeks before the cancellation" shows you can separate cause from consequence.
"I" not "we" at the point of error	Use "we" for the project, "I" for the mistake. That ratio is the whole ownership signal.
A named concept	Stated versus revealed preference, in plain words. Your discipline, used rather than recited.
Something defended	Owning the error *and* standing behind the cancellation shows judgement, not just contrition.
Evidence of change	The thing nearly every candidate leaves out.

11 What to cut

Cut	Because
"We were under pressure from the organisers" *as the explanation*	**The main trap.** Fine as a reason you behaved badly; fatal as a reason the event failed.
"Unfortunately" / "sadly" / "it was just one of those things"	Softeners that imply it happened to you rather than that you did it.
"I was really upset about it"	One clause of honest feeling is fine. More than that and it is about your emotions rather than your judgement.
"I learned the importance of planning"	The emptiest sentence available. You have a far better lesson.
"In hindsight we should have marketed it better"	Vague. Say exactly which decision, and when.
Blaming the committee or anyone by name	Same rule as always. Never let the other people in your story be the problem.
Any invented number	If you genuinely cannot remember, say "I think it was around" and give a range. Do not make one up.

12 Follow-ups

They ask	You say
"What would you do differently?"	Be specific and sequential. "Sell first, commit second. I'd have taken deposits or sold a minimum number before booking anything, so the worst case was a small event rather than no event."
"Whose fault was it?"	Do not spread it. "It was a committee thing, but the bit I got wrong was mine — I was the one reading the interest as demand."
"Was cancelling the right call?"	"Yes, and I'd still defend it. The money already spent was gone either way; running it half empty would just have added to it."
"That sounds quite minor."	**Do not get defensive and do not apologise.** "It is, in the scheme of things. But it's the clearest example I've got of me getting a judgement wrong and being able to say exactly why, which I think is more useful than a bigger story I understood less well."
"How did you feel?"	Be human, briefly. "Embarrassed, mostly — we'd told people it was happening." Then move straight back to the diagnosis.

BEFORE YOU FILM

- **Answer the four questions in section 4.** Especially: how many did you need, how many did you sell, and what was *your* specific job. Without those you have an anecdote, not an answer.
- **Pick one cause from the menu and commit to it.** Two causes is a muddle. One, named precisely, is a diagnosis.
- **Decide your evidence-of-change line** and keep it to one sentence.
- **Check you are not reusing the house-hunt lesson** if teamwork is also in your set.
- **Say it out loud once** and listen for whether you sound like you are explaining or excusing. If any sentence starts with "but", look at it again.

What is mine and what is yours. The event, the cancellation and the pressure are yours. I have invented nothing and I do not know what caused the shortfall — section 4 is a menu, not a diagnosis, and you must pick the true one. The stated-versus-revealed preference framing, the point that the failure predates the cancellation, and the distinction between the error and the response are my additions. Every bracketed figure is yours to supply, and you should not say any of them unless they are true. If you genuinely cannot reconstruct the numbers, give a range and say it is approximate — that is honest and costs you almost nothing.